Pranjal Yadav, was a Yadav only gave added ammunition to the BJP propaganda machine, with a rumour being quietly spread that he was related to UP's ruling family.

By the time the DM relented, it was too late. The BJP was keen to turn adversity into advantage. Playing victim, Modi accused the Election Commission of bias and acting under political pressure. The Chief Election Commissioner V.S. Sampath is a quiet, lowprofile man with a non-confrontational persona, very unlike some of his predecessors, such as T.N. Seshan. The charge of bias left Sampath nonplussed. 'We have tried our best to ensure a free and fair elections—why is Modi talking like this?' he asked me when I called him up for a reaction. Sampath, too, was slowly learning that Modi was not your average politician. His instinctively combative nature meant that even the Election Commission would not be spared his ire (as another CEC, J.M. Lyngdoh, had discovered in 2002).

Modi was determined to have the last word. Landing in Varanasi, he chose to go on an impromptu roadshow through the city right up to the party headquarters. If the nomination journey had been a march of triumph, this was a final act of defiance. On 24 April, the masses had come out in large numbers. This time, the streets were dominated by BJP supporters in saffron caps. I asked Jaitley if the roadshow was also another 'well-planned' event. 'Well, you can't expect a political party to stay silent if we are denied our right to hold a rally,' was his prompt answer.

From day one of this election campaign, the BJP, unlike the Congress, had never missed an opportunity to seize an opportunity. Varanasi's DM, intentionally or otherwise, had provided them with one last moment to exploit. On the final day of the campaign, Rahul Gandhi went on a similar roadshow through the city's streets. It looked imitative and, frankly, a little late as always. Rahul once again lived up to the rather harsh description of him as a 'tubelight'.

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